WE'RE ON THE **CUSP OF UNPRECEDENTED GROWTH** IN INDIAN MEDIA AND ENTERTAINMENT. MUCH LIKE **KOREA HAD ITS GLOBAL CULTURAL MOMENT** IN THE LAST DECADE, THIS NEXT DECADE WILL BE INDIA'S

constantly moving in the direction of delivering greater control of the experience into the hands of the audience, they will now want to control and be an active participant in the very substance of their entertainment as well. The era of high-quality, pre-produced "one to many" entertainment will change to interactive, immersive and bespoke "many to one" entertainment.

Broadcast television, both network and cable, is rapidly declining in mature TV markets of the developed world with rampant "cord-cutting". In India, however, multiple realities operate simultaneously across distinct socio-economic demographic groups, each with significant population sizes. And thus, television is still growing alongside streaming platforms. There will be a time when the migration occurs, but that time is not now. This is the unique benefit of the demographic dividend we have inherited, with scores of people moving up the economic ladder from poverty to low-income to middle-income groups and onwards, driving consumption across all media platforms simultaneously, without one cannibalising on the other for now.

Streaming will see consolidation, particularly in India, with the market unable to commercially sustain the more than 30 streaming platforms that exist currently. "Streaming wars", as they are dramatically called in the media, will doubtless continue, and that is great news for audiences who will continue to have a mouth-watering smorgasbord of viewing choices to entertain them. This is a golden period for creators, performers and all those allied with the audio-visual industry. Data costs in India have dropped to one of the lowest in the world, and so the low price point of streaming video content now meets the insatiable desire amongst our audiences for non-stop entertainment. The vast array of content across formats and durations—from Instagram reels and YouTube videos to general entertainment channel (GEC) soap operas and premium quality TV series, to movies from all over the country and the world, dubbed and subtitled across multiple languages—has led to India becoming the highest consumer of data across the world.

The concept of stardom has also undergone a change. Today, the phenomenon of a global movie star like Tom Cruise has morphed into the global stardom of Spider-Man, Iron Man or Doctor Strange as characters, rather than the stardom necessarily accruing to the actors who play them. Similarly, in India, the value of franchises like *K.G.F* or *Golmaal* has become increasingly significant as against the cult devotion that Amitabh Bachchan enjoyed through the 1970s or Shah Rukh Khan through the 1990s, in whichever film they might have appeared. Again, one speaks in absolutes to make a point, so there will always be exceptions. But it does appear that the age of the all-encompassing, multi-generational, universally adored superstar has moved on to cult fan followings for characters and franchises.

Live entertainment is a much-neglected sector of the media and entertainment business, and so far, it has produced content that caters only to the upper social-economic strata of the audience in major metros. There is huge potential for explosive growth in this sector if the latent desire in smaller centres for new entertainment experiences coupled with their growing purchasing power is tapped into, with the creation of mainstream content that appeals to this audience. This is a sector to watch out for in the years to come, both in terms of its potential for explosive growth as well as the opportunity for truly revolutionary innovation in content.

All in all, I believe we are on the cusp of an unprecedented growth phase in Indian media and entertainment. Much like Korea had its global cultural moment in the last decade, this next decade will be India's. We see signs of it already with some of our movies and series crossing over to mainstream audiences and gaining traction at the Oscars, Golden Globes and Emmys. While this has been happening sporadically so far, I shall once again boldly stick my neck out and say that by 2030, India will become a major force influencing global popular culture, with our unique storytelling voices and choices creating lasting cultural impact. Here's to 2023 being the year we take some big leaps ahead to make that a reality. ■